

On two other occasions, Andromache prophesies her fate and that of her son and of the city, each time addressing Hector's corpse. Here is how she takes her farewell of him (24. 725–738):

"My husband, you were young when you were taken from life, and you leave me a widow in the palace. The boy is still just a baby, who is our child, yours and mine, ill-fated that we are. I do not think that he will grow to manhood, for the city will first be utterly sacked now that you, its guardian, are dead, who defended the city, the chaste wives, and the little children. They will soon go away in the hollow ships, and I with them. And you, my child, either will go with me, where you will perform demeaning tasks, laboring for a harsh master; or else one of the Achaeans will take you by the hand and hurl you in anger from the tower—a grim death—because Hector once killed his brother or father or son."

10

Indeed, Andromache became the slave of Neoptolemus after the fall of Troy, and her infant son Astyanax was thrown from the city walls.

A major development in the theme of Achilles' wrath occurs in the ninth book. Should Achilles have relented when Agamemnon offered to restore Briseis with many valuable gifts? It is a measure of his sensitive and passionate nature that he refused the offer, presented by three envoys, Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax, son of Telamon.

Odysseus' speech to Achilles echoes for the most part the directions given by Agamemnon, but it begins and ends with more tactful and artful persuasion. In describing the successes of the Trojans, Odysseus emphasizes the danger to Achilles and the opportunity to destroy Hector. The fury of Hector cannot wait to come down to destroy their ships. Then he lists the gifts to be given to Achilles immediately upon his return: seven tripods, ten talents of gold, twenty shining cauldrons, twelve prize-winning horses, seven women from Lesbos, particularly beautiful and skilled (whom Achilles had picked out for himself when he took Lesbos!), and Briseis, with a solemn oath that Agamemnon had never slept with her. In addition, if the gods were to grant that Priam's city be sacked, Achilles might heap up his ship with gold and bronze and choose twenty Trojan women for himself, the most beautiful after Helen. Beyond this, if they return safely to Greece, Agamemnon promises to make Achilles his son-in-law, with a dowry larger than any ever given before and a kingdom of seven rich cities over which he might rule like a god.

At the conclusion of his speech, Odysseus is careful not to repeat Agamemnon's final instructions: "Let him be subdued—Hades is the most hateful of gods and mortals because he is inexorable and inflexible. Let him submit to me, inasmuch as I am more royal and assert that I am the elder" (9. 158–161). Instead Odysseus, with more tact and wisdom, begs that Achilles, even if his anger and hatred of Agamemnon are too great for forgiveness, should at least have pity on the other Greeks, who are worn out in battle and will upon his return honor him like a god. In conclusion, Odysseus tries to win Achilles over by playing upon his jealousy of Hector's arrogant success, implying that now is his chance to achieve his desire for glory through the defeat of Hector, who thinks that no Greek is his match. By questioning some of these values in his reply, Achilles reveals a sensitivity and introspection that make him unique (9. 309–345):



Audio

“I must give a direct answer to your speech, telling you honestly what I think and what I will do, so that you ambassadors may not try to wheedle me one after the other. For I hate the man who hides one thing in his heart and says something else as much as I hate Hades and his realm. I will say outright what seems to me best. I do not believe that the son of Atreus, Agamemnon, will persuade me, nor will the other Greeks, since it was no pleasure for me always to fight against the enemy relentlessly. The coward is held in equal honor with the brave man who endures and fights hard, and equal is his fate. The one who does nothing and the one who does much find a similar end in death. It was no advantage to me when I suffered deeply, continually risking my life in battle. As a bird brings food to her unfledged nestlings, after she has won it with much distress, so I used to spend many sleepless nights and endure days of blood in fighting against enemies belligerent in the defense of their wives. (9. 309–327) 10

Indeed, I say to you, I plundered twelve populated cities by ship and attacked another eleven by land; from all these I took many splendid treasures and brought them back to give to Agamemnon, the son of Atreus. He who had remained behind by his swift ships took them, distributing a few things but keeping much for himself. All that he gave as prizes to the nobles and kings they keep secure; it was from me alone of the Achaeans that he stole. 20 He has a dear wife; let him sleep with her for his pleasure. Why must the Greeks fight with the Trojans? Why did the son of Atreus gather an army to bring here? Was it not on account of Helen with her beautiful hair? Are the sons of Atreus the only ones among mortals who love their wives? To be sure, any decent and responsible man loves and cares for his own, just as I loved Briseïs from the depths of my heart, even though she was won by my spear. As it is now, since he took my prize out of my hands and deceived me, let him not try me, since I know him too well—he will not persuade me.” (9. 328–345)

Achilles’ response continues at some length. He makes it clear that he despises gifts from Agamemnon, however grand they may be, and he has no need or desire to be chosen as his son-in-law. Surely Agamemnon could find someone more royal and worthy of respect! The shameless Agamemnon, “dog that he is, would not dare to look me in the face!” The gifts are excessively generous, but Achilles sees through Agamemnon’s façade. This is not reconciliation but bribery. Many critics have said, with some justice, that Achilles by his rejection of these gifts has gone too far in his pride and that he is guilty of the sin of hubris. He should understand, they say, that Agamemnon cannot humiliate himself by coming to Achilles with apologies, as if to a god. Is it really too much, however, to ask a good king to admit his error in person? Agamemnon by his royal arrogance may be as guilty as Achilles, if not more so, because he, the commander-in-chief, is ultimately responsible for all the slaughter and suffering that might have been avoided.

So Agamemnon’s attempt to win Achilles back has failed. Achilles’ old tutor, Phoenix, also tries to persuade Achilles, but to no avail. In the course of his speech, he draws a parallel between Achilles and the hero, Meleager, who foolishly rejected gifts (see the Appendix to this chapter).

The third envoy, the warrior Ajax, son of Telamon, bluntly concludes the embassy (9. 628–638):

“Achilles has put a savage and proud spirit within his breast. Obdurate, he does not care for the love of his friends, with which we honored him above all men beside the ships, unpitying as he is. Yet others have accepted payment for the death of a brother or a son. . . . But the gods have put in your breast a spirit unforgiving and harsh, because of one girl.”

Without Achilles, the Greeks were driven back by the Trojans until Hector began to set fire to the ships. All this was done, says Homer, in fulfillment of the will of Zeus (1. 5), for Zeus had agreed to honor Achilles in this way after Thetis had prayed to him to avenge the wrong done by Agamemnon.

When Hector broke through to the Greek ships, Achilles finally allowed his friend and companion, Patroclus, to take his armor and fight Hector and the Trojans. For a while, Patroclus carried all before him, even killing Sarpedon, son of Zeus. But he went too far in his fury. Homer (16. 786–867) describes how Apollo opposed him in the battle and struck him across the back with his hand. Patroclus was dazed by the blow, and the Trojan Euphorbus wounded him with a spear. It was left for Hector to deal the deathblow to the enfeebled and stunned Patroclus.

The death of Patroclus is the turning point of the epic. Achilles is overcome by grief, guilt, and remorse. His anguish is so terrifying that his comrades fear he may take his own life. Yet his mother, Thetis, provides comfort once again as Achilles steadfastly makes the tragic decision to return to battle to avenge Patroclus and so, assuredly, to fix the seal upon his own fate. At the beginning of Book 18, Antilochus, son of Nestor, who brings the tragic news of Patroclus’ death, finds Achilles agonized with anxiety and fear that Patroclus has ignored his warning not to fight Hector and is dead. Antilochus, in tears, addresses Achilles (18. 18–38):

“Ah, son of brave Peleus, you must hear my painful message—how I wish this had never happened—Patroclus lies dead and they are fighting over his corpse, which is naked. Hector with the flashing helmet has taken his armor.” (18. 18–21)

Thus he spoke, and a black cloud of grief enveloped Achilles. He clutched the black dirt with both his hands and poured it over his head, and his handsome face was defiled. The dark filth covered his immortal tunic and he, his mighty self, lay stretched out mightily on the ground, and he tore at his hair and befouled it. (18. 22–27)

And the women whom Achilles and Patroclus had taken as captives, stricken to the heart with grief, cried aloud and ran out to surround great Achilles, and they all beat their breasts and the limbs of each of them went limp. Antilochus also by his side, shedding tears and lamenting, restrained the hands of Achilles, whose proud heart was overwhelmed with sorrow, because he feared that he would cut his throat with his sword. Achilles cried out a terrifying scream of woe, and his divine mother heard him, as she sat beside her aged father Nereus in the depths of the sea and in turn she answered with a cry. The goddesses gathered around her, all her sister Nereids who were there in the deep sea. (18. 28–38)

Homer goes on to name all these Nereids in lines that read very much like a catalogue that might have been composed by Hesiod. Homer then continues (18. 50–126):



Audio

Together all the Nereids beat their breasts and Thetis began her lament: (50–51)

“Hear me, my sisters, daughters of Nereus, so that all of you, once you have listened, will know well how many sorrows are in my heart. Ah, poor me, unhappy mother of the best of sons born for an evil fate, since I give birth to a child, both blameless and strong, the best of heroes. He shot up like a young sapling, and I nurtured him and he flourished like a tree, growing up strong, the pride of the orchard. But then I sent him forth with the curved ships to battle against the Trojans on Ilium. He will not return home to the house of Peleus, and I will never get him back again. All the while that he lives and looks upon the light of the sun, he suffers in anguish, and when I go to him I am not able to help him at all. Nevertheless, I will go to him in order to see my dear son and I will listen to the sorrow that has come to him as he stays out of the battle.” (18. 52–64)

Thetis lamented thus and left her cavern and her sisters went with her, in tears, and the swell of the sea broke and gave way. When they reached fertile Troy, they all came to shore in an orderly stream, where the cluster of the Myrmidons’ ships were anchored close by swift Achilles. His divine mother stood before him, as she heaved a deep sigh, and uttering a sharp cry she clasped the head of her son and grieving spoke winged words: “My son, why are you weeping? What sorrow has touched your heart? Tell me and don’t keep it hidden. These things have been brought to fulfillment through Zeus, just as you once wanted, lifting your hands in prayer that all the sons of the Achaeans be pinned against the prows of their ships and suffer terrible atrocities, all because of their need for you.” (18. 65–77)

Achilles, swift of foot, groaning deeply answered: “Mother, Olympian Zeus has accomplished these things for me but what joy is there in them now, since my dear friend has perished, Patroclus, whom I loved more than my other comrades, loved as much as my own life. I have lost him. Hector has killed him and stripped him of my mighty armor, wondrous to behold. The gods gave it to Peleus, a splendid gift, on the day when they brought you to the bed of a mortal man. How I wish you had continued to live among the immortal goddesses of the sea and Peleus had won a mortal wife! But as it is now there must be endless sorrow in your heart for the death of your son, whom you will never welcome back again, as he returns home. For I have no more heart to go on living, unless Hector first is struck down by my spear and loses his life and pays the price for stripping my armor from Patroclus, son of Menoetius.” (18. 78–93)

Thetis then in turn answered him amidst her tears: “My son, your life will soon be over from what you are saying. For right after the death of Hector, your own death is at hand.” (18. 94–96)

Then in great distress Achilles, swift of foot, answered her: “So may I die at once, since it was never destined to save my comrade from death. He has perished very far from his fatherland because he did not have me, with my prowess in war, as protector. Now then alas I will not return to my fatherland and I did not become any light of salvation for Patroclus or my other comrades,

so many of whom were struck down by mighty Hector. But I sit by my ships, useless, a burden on the earth, though I am superior in battle like no other of the bronze-armored Achaeans, even if others are better speakers in counsel. I wish strife would disappear from among both gods and human beings and wrath, which has sent even the most sensible into a rage and which, much more sweet than the dripping of honey, wells up in the breasts of men like smoke. Thus the king of men Agamemnon enraged me, but we will let this be a thing of the past, and even though I am angry I will overcome the anger in my heart because I have to. For now I will go back into battle so that I may seek out Hector, the slayer of my dear friend. I will accept my own death whenever Zeus wishes to bring it about or the other immortal gods. For not even Heracles in his might escaped death, he who was most dear to Zeus the king, son of Cronus, but fate defeated him and the fierce anger of Hera. So I too, if a like fate has been fashioned for me, will lie down in acceptance when death comes. But now may I win goodly renown and compel some one of the Trojan women or deep-girdled Dardanians to wipe away the tears from her tender cheeks with both her hands in her outburst of grief and may they so realize that I have stayed away from the fighting for too long a time. Do not try to keep me away from the battle, however much you love me because you will not persuade me.” (18. 97–126)

Thetis sadly agrees with Achilles’ tragic decision to determine his own death by avenging Patroclus, and she tells him that she will go to Hephaestus to have new armor made for him.

Grief over the death of Patroclus drove Achilles to end his quarrel with Agamemnon and to return to the fighting with one goal, to kill Hector. So Briseis was returned with costly gifts, and upon her return she lamented over the corpse of Patroclus (19. 287–300):

“Patroclus, most dear to my unhappy heart, I left you alive when I was taken from the hut, and now upon my return I find you, leader of the host, dead. Thus for me evil follows upon evil. I saw my husband, to whom my father and lady mother gave me, transfixed by a sharp spear in front of his city, and my dear brothers, all three born to our mother, on that day found their way to ruinous death. You would not let me cry when swift Achilles killed my husband and sacked the city of godlike Mynes, but you said that I would be made the wedded wife of godlike Achilles and that I would be taken back in his ship to Phthia to celebrate our marriage among the Myrmidons. So I lament for you unceasingly, you who were always gentle.”

Thetis brought new armor, made by Hephaestus, to her son. Homer describes the shield of Achilles in detail, with its portrayal of the human world of the Mycenaean cities at war and at peace, scenes of farming and other peaceful activities (a lawsuit, for example, marriage, dancing, and music).

Meanwhile, Hector has spoiled Patroclus’ corpse of the armor of Achilles, which he himself put on. As he changes his armor, Zeus watches and foretells his doom (17. 194–208):

He put on the immortal armor of Achilles, son of Peleus, which the gods had given to his father and he in turn in his old age gave to Achilles his

son. But the son did not grow old in the armor. And when Zeus the cloud-gatherer saw Hector from afar arming himself with the arms of the god-like son of Peleus, he moved his head and spoke to his own heart: "Ah, wretched man! You do not now think of death that will come close to you. You are putting on the immortal arms of the best of men, before whom others also tremble. That man's friend you have killed, gentle and strong, and you have taken the arms from his head and shoulders, as you should not have done. For now I will give you great strength. In return, Andromache will never take the noble arms of the son of Peleus from you when you return from battle." 10

Achilles returned to the battle and drove the Trojans back to the city, in his rage fighting even the river-god Scamander and filling the river with Trojan corpses. Eventually, the Trojans were driven into the city, and only Hector remained outside the wall. The single combat between Hector and Achilles is the climax of the *Iliad*. Hector is chased by Achilles three times around the walls; "as in a dream the pursuer cannot catch him who is running away, nor can he who runs escape nor the other catch him" (22. 199–200). Finally, Zeus agrees to the death of Hector (*Iliad*, 22. 209–214):

Then indeed the Father held up the golden scales, and in them he put two lots of grievous death, the one for Achilles, and the other for Hector, tamer of horses, and he held the scales by the middle. And the fatal day of Hector sank down toward the house of Hades. Then Phoebus Apollo left Hector, and Athena, the grey-eyed goddess, came to the son of Peleus.

Athena helps Achilles by leading Hector to his death through treachery. She takes the form of his brother, Deïphobus, in whom Hector, now rendered defenseless, puts his final trust (22. 294–301):

He called with a great shout to white-shielded Deïphobus and asked for a long spear, but Deïphobus was nowhere near him. And Hector knew the truth in his heart and said, "Alas! Now for sure the gods have summoned me deathward. For I thought that the hero Deïphobus was beside me, but he is inside the walls and Athena has deceived me. Now indeed evil death is not far away but very near, and I have no way out."

Deserted by the gods and deceived by Athena, Hector died at the hands of Achilles, who refused to show any mercy and dragged the corpse back to his hut behind his chariot. Next Achilles celebrated the funeral of Patroclus, on whose pyre he sacrificed twelve Trojan prisoners. He also held athletic games in honor of Patroclus, at which he presided and gave valuable prizes for the winners. Yet his anger against Hector was still unassuaged, and daily for twelve days he dragged Hector's body round the tomb of Patroclus behind his chariot; the mutilated corpse was refreshed and restored by Apollo each day. Only when Thetis brought him the message of Zeus was Achilles ready to relent. Priam himself, with the help of Hermes, came to Achilles' hut and ransomed the corpse of his son. The scene where the old man kneels before the killer of so many of his sons is one of the most moving in all Greek saga (24. 477–484):

Priam and Achilles. Red-figure skyphos, by the Brygos painter, ca. 490 B.C. This is one of the finest and most striking renderings of the Ransom of Hector. Priam, white haired and holding a walking staff, approaches Achilles from the left. Behind Priam four attendants, two men (shown here) followed by two women, bring the gifts. Achilles reclines on a banquet couch alongside the banquet table still laden with food. The couch, covered with mattress and blanket, is handsomely built and decorated. Achilles is turning to address a serving boy. He holds a piece of meat in his left hand, which rests on two large cushions, and a dagger in his right, which he has brought to his lips. Achilles has not yet noticed Priam's arrival. Hector's wounded body can clearly be seen beneath the couch in full view. While this detail is contrary to Homer's tale, vase painters often included the body of Hector for dramatic effect. Another added feature is the presence of Hector's (formerly Achilles') armor on the wall and a shield with a gorgoneion (a representation of a stylized head of a gorgon). The artist has also taken liberties with the timing of the scene. In Homer, Achilles has just finished eating when Priam enters. This slight change has resulted in a stark contrast that is particularly gruesome: Achilles eating meat with the corpse beneath, while grease from the food drips onto the bloody body. The horror of the scene is fully realized when one recalls both Achilles' vow to refrain from eating until he has avenged the death of Patroclus and his threat to Hector, just before he kills him, that if he had the heart he would tear his flesh apart and eat him raw. (*Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look

Great Priam entered, unseen by Achilles' companions, and stood near Achilles. With his hands he took hold of Achilles' knees and kissed his hands, hands terrible and man-killing, which had killed many of Priam's sons. . . . Achilles was full of wonder as he looked at godlike Priam, and the others also wondered and they looked at each other.

When Priam has made his appeal to Achilles and they both have had their fill of lamentation, each remembering his sorrows, Achilles explains the ultimate reason for human misery (24. 524–532):

"No [human] action is without chilling grief. For thus the gods have spun out for wretched mortals the fate of living in distress, while they live without care. Two jars sit on the doorsill of Zeus, filled with gifts that he bestows, one jar of evils, the other of blessings. When Zeus, who delights in thunder, takes from both and mixes the bad with the good, a human being at one time encounters evil, and at another good. But the one to whom Zeus gives only troubles from the jar of sorrows, this one he makes an object of abuse, to be driven by cruel misery over the divine earth."



The Death of Hector, by Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640); 43 × 50 in. A *modello* is the second stage of preparatory designs for a tapestry, following a smaller oil sketch and preceding a larger cartoon. Rubens designed a series of eight tapestries depicting *The Life of Achilles*, of which *The Death of Hector* was the seventh. Since tapestry weavers worked from the back of the web, the figures in the *modello* are left-handed. The scene depicts the fatal thrust of Achilles' spear (which had been given back to Achilles by Athena after it had first missed its target) into Hector's throat (*Iliad* 22.326–329). Hector, armed only with a sword (for his spear, too, had missed its mark, but there was no goddess to restore it), looks at Achilles, still able to ask for a decent burial. His request will be denied, for his body will be dragged round the walls of Troy (shown in the right background with anxious Trojans gathered before the towers of the gate and on the walls) by the horses that appear in the left background. Athena, accompanied by her owl and with a spear in her left hand, hovers above to give encouragement to Achilles. Prominent in the center is the shield of Achilles, the subject of much of Book 18 of the *Iliad*, and behind it flows the river Scamander. The herm (a column with the head of a divine figure) on the left represents Heracles, who had first sacked Troy (see p. 561): His club rests against the herm. The herm on the right represents Ares, whose head is turned away from Hector. Above two *putti* hold a cartouche, into which a Latin metrical inscription was inserted in the tapestry. At the bottom is an altar, on which lie two cornucopias filled with the victor's palm fronds; in its center are two fighting cocks. (LAMMERTSE, FRISO AND VERGARA, ALEJANDRO; PETER PAUL RUBENS, *THE LIFE OF ACHILLES* © 2003 NAI Publishers Rotterdam)

Through suffering, Achilles has finally learned true compassion. His pessimistic view of human existence lies at the core of the Greek tragic view of life. It is a view mirrored with sad beauty by Herodotus, as we have seen in Chapter 6, and echoed again and again by the dramatists, who delight in the splendid fall of those who were once great and blessed. “Never count a person happy until dead.”



The Funeral of Patroclus. Apulian red-figure krater by the Darius painter, ca. 330 B.C.; height 56 in. In the central panel is the pyre with Hector's spoils (originally Achilles' armor worn by Patroclus) on it. To its left Achilles holds a Trojan prisoner by her hair before running her through with his sword: three other bound prisoners to the left await the same fate. To the right of the pyre Agamemnon pours a libation. In the lower panel, the charioteer of Achilles, Automedon, prepares to drag the corpse of Hector behind the fourhorse chariot around the tomb of Patroclus. In the upper register of the central panel, the old warriors Nestor (seated) and Phoenix converse in a tent. (*Scala/Ministero per i Beni e le Attività culturali/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look

So Priam ransomed Hector and returned to Troy with the corpse. The *Iliad* ends with the funeral of Hector, over whose body Andromache, Hecuba, and finally Helen had poured out their lamentations. For nine days the people of Troy mourned for Hector, whose death had made inevitable their own fate.

Achilles is not only subject to vehement passions. Alone of the Greek heroes he knows his destiny clearly: to Odysseus' speech in the embassy he replies (9. 410–416):

My mother, Thetis of the silver feet, has told me that two fates are carrying me to the goal of my death. If I stay here and fight before the city of the Trojans, then I lose my homecoming, but my glory will never fade. But if I return home to my own dear land, then gone is my noble glory, and my life will be long.

The character of Achilles is perfectly expressed in these words. When his horse, Xanthus, prophesies his death (19. 404–417), Achilles replies:

Well do I know that my destiny is to die here, far from my dear father and mother. Even so, I shall keep on. I shall not stop until I have harried the Trojans enough with my warfare. (19. 421–423)

Again, when the dying Hector foretells Achilles' death, Achilles resolutely accepts his fate. Nor is Achilles always violent. At the funeral games for Patroclus, he presides with princely dignity and even makes peace between the hot-tempered competitors. We have also seen how he gave up his anger against Hector and treated Priam with dignity and generosity. Achilles is a splendid and complex hero, incomparably the greatest figure in the Trojan saga.

The Olympian Gods in Battle

The gods are all-important participants in the Trojan War. We have seen in Chapter 5 (pp. 125–128) how Hephaestus settles the quarrel between Zeus and Hera at the end of the first book of the *Iliad*, an episode that vividly displays the gulf between mortal and immortal emotions. The first book sets forth the quarrel between Agamemnon and Achilles, which (as the poet says in the second line of the poem) ends in the death of so many people. In contrast, the quarrel between Zeus and Hera ends in laughter and lovemaking. We also have seen in Chapter 5 (p. 117) the sacred marriage of Zeus and Hera in Book 14 of the *Iliad*, the union of sky-god and earth-goddess. Usually, the gods are distant observers of human battle, which is nevertheless a direct concern to them. Yet individual gods and goddesses sometimes take part in battle by helping or protecting their mortal favorites.

In two episodes (which are called **theomachies**), however, the gods themselves fight each other on the battlefield. In the first of these, Athena descends to the battle in a chariot with Hera. We translate here the description of her arming (*Iliad* 5. 736–747):

Athena put on a tunic and armed herself for tear-filled battle with the armor of Zeus, the cloud-gatherer. Round her shoulders she put the tasseled aegis, a fearsome sight, ringed all around with Fear. In it is Strife, in it is Might, in it is icy Pursuit, in it is the head of the frightening monster Gorgon—a terrible and grim image, the sign of Zeus the aegis-carrier. On her head she put the double-crested golden helmet with its four metal plates, decorated with images of defenders of a hundred cities. She climbed into the fiery chariot, she grasped the heavy, long spear, with which she lays low the ranks of men with whom she, daughter of a mighty Father, is angry.

She helps Diomedes and herself takes part in the fighting. Even Aphrodite enters the battle and is wounded by Diomedes—a mortal wounding an immortal. Aphrodite returns to Olympus and is comforted by her mother, Dione (*Iliad* 5. 382–384):

Be patient, my child, and endure, even though you are in pain. For many of us who dwell in the palaces of Olympus have endured suffering caused by men, causing harsh pain to each other.

The Universality of the *Iliad*

Since the *Iliad*, if not before, war has served as one of the greatest themes in all literature, a universal human experience, one that lays bare the extremes of human character and passion and explores with wrenching intensity the heights and depths of human relationships. What age has not known war, despite all condemnation, a universal and persistent plague? What man and woman does not care about how they are seen by others? Who has never let rage control action? Who has not had to face an encounter and quailed before it in fear? Who has never felt controlled by a greater power that cares little for the lot of humans and has never questioned standards of moral behavior or concluded that we are all victims and that injustice too often motivates human action? The archetypal Trojan War has become a mirror through which we see war forever, not only in all its devastating horror and brutality but also in the lofty grandeur of the achievements it can inspire in the face of life and death: we see men and women, husbands and wives, brothers and sisters challenged by the most harrowing ordeals, which put them to the test and define their bravery or cowardice, their love or betrayal, their selfishness or their patriotism. The great heroes and heroines of the *Iliad*, in their diversity and scope, transcend the mores of their time and place to epitomize us all. It is easy to recognize not only the men as prototypes but also the women from the depth and grandeur of individual depictions: Andromache, the deeply devoted wife of Hector and mother of Astyanax; Hecuba, the powerful and aged queen, loving wife and mother, who sees her Hector killed and will eventually lose her husband and all her children and be reduced to utter desolation; Helen, trapped by her own passion, as she herself admits, between two opposing forces, a woman of grand stature, the focal point of the entire struggle. The reinterpretations of Helen's character since the time of Homer to the present day have been legion, with judgments ranging from guilty whore to guiltless victim.²² Her beauty has inspired countless poems: Christopher Marlowe made her an object of sensual desire in *Dr. Faustus* with the lines beginning, "Was this the face that launched a thousand ships/and burn't the topless towers of Ilium?" For Goethe, in *Faust* (part 2, act 3), she symbolized all that is beautiful in classical antiquity (see Chapter 27 on the companion website).

The universality of the *Iliad* and the devastating truth of Homer's depiction of war and its hero Achilles find powerful and specific confirmation in a book by Jonathan Shay that illuminates the experiences and sufferings of Vietnam veterans through a study of the *Iliad*, in particular the character and emotions of Achilles.²³ Shay, a psychiatrist who appreciates Homer's contemporary value, finds parallel themes such as these: betrayal of "what's right" by a commander; the shrinkage of social and moral horizons; intense comradeship reduced to a few friends; and the death of one of these special comrades, followed by feelings of grief and guilt culminating in a berserk rage.

Dione goes on to name gods who have been wounded by mortals. Finally, Zeus, alerted by Athena and Hera, says to Aphrodite (*Iliad* 5. 428–430):

Battle is not your gift, my child. You should busy yourself with the work of desire and love. Leave all this business to swift Ares and Athena.

Diomedes wounds even the god of war himself, Ares, who complains to Zeus and finds little sympathy (see p. 131).

The second theomachy is in Books 20 and 21. In the Council of the Gods at the beginning of Book 20, Zeus gives the gods permission to fight on the field of battle, while he remains above it all (*Iliad* 20. 22–25):

I will stay here in a fold of Olympus: I will watch from my seat and delight my mind. You other gods may go to the Trojans and Achaeans and give help to both sides, wherever you decide.

Thus the battle becomes more violent, as the gods inspire the heroes with fighting spirit and themselves take part. Once again the contrast is drawn between the reality of human suffering and the triviality of the gods' injuries. Mortals must fight and die: the wounds of the immortals are soon healed.

Not all the gods who are on the battlefield fight. Poseidon challenges Apollo, who replies (*Iliad* 21. 462–467):

Earth-shaker, you would not say I was prudent if I were to fight you for the sake of wretched mortals. They are like leaves that flourish with fiery colors, for a little while eating the fruits of the earth. Then they fade away and perish, lifeless. Let us, however, stop fighting now, and let mortals fight.

The theomachies help us see the unbridgeable gap between the mortal and the divine. They show that it *is* ridiculous for gods to fight like mortals, yet they also show that human warfare is a concern of the Olympians. The theomachies, by recognizing the triviality of divine pain, serve to illuminate human suffering. Nor should we take them too seriously: we end this discussion with the description of Hera's attack on Artemis (*Iliad* 21. 489–496):

Hera spoke and with her left hand seized Artemis by her wrists. With her right hand she stripped the bow and arrows from her shoulder, and with a smile she boxed her ears and stunned her. Out fell the arrows from the quiver. In tears the goddess [Artemis] fled like a pigeon that flies into a hole in a rock chased by a hawk (for it was not fated that the pigeon should be caught)—even so did Artemis run away in tears and left her bow and arrows there.

The Fall of Troy

The brilliance of the *Iliad* makes the rest of the saga of the Trojan War pale by comparison. Episodes are recorded in summaries of lost epics, in drama, in many vase paintings, and in Vergil's *Aeneid*, so that we can tell the story of the rest of the war.

Achilles and Penthesilea

After the funeral of Hector, the fighting resumed, and Achilles killed the leaders of two contingents that came from the ends of the earth to help the Trojans. From the north came the Amazons—the legendary warrior women—led

by Penthesilea. Achilles killed her; in some versions, just as Achilles was about to deal the fatal thrust, their eyes met and he fell in love with her.²⁴ Achilles mourned over her death and her beauty and killed Thersites, who taunted him.²⁵ For this murder Achilles had to withdraw for a time to Lesbos, where he was purified by Odysseus.

Achilles and Memnon

A second foreign contingent was that of the Ethiopians, from the south. They were led by Memnon, son of Eos (Aurora), goddess of the dawn, and of Tithonus (a brother of Priam). After Memnon's death, his followers were turned into birds that fought around his tomb. Achilles did not long survive these victories.

The Death of Achilles

As he pursued the Trojans toward the city, Achilles was fatally wounded in the heel by an arrow shot by Paris with the help of Apollo. After a fierce fight, his corpse was recovered by Ajax, son of Telamon, and buried at Sigeum, the promontory near Troy. Agamemnon's ghost tells the ghost of Achilles about the battle over his corpse and his splendid funeral. The Greeks prepared the corpse for cremation and shaved their heads. Thetis herself came from the sea accompanied by her sea-nymphs, and, with the Muses, they mourned with wailing and dirges, while the Greeks wept (*Odyssey* 24. 63–70):

For seventeen days and nights, immortal gods and mortal men, we wept for you. On the eighteenth we gave you to burning fire, and we sacrificed flocks of fat sheep. You were burned in the clothing of the gods, anointed with oil and sweet honey. Many of the Achaean heroes paraded in armor around the burning pyre, men on foot and horseback, and a loud roar arose.

Agamemnon describes how Achilles' bones were put in a golden urn by Thetis, mixed with those of Patroclus. Then the great tomb was raised, and Thetis gave funeral games in honor of her dead son. Thus Achilles, the greatest of Greek heroes, was given a funeral and burial that would ensure his fame for posterity.²⁶ (See *The Funeral of Patroclus*, p. 499.)

The ghost of Achilles appeared to the Greeks after the sack of Troy and demanded that Polyxena, the daughter of Priam and Hecuba, be sacrificed at his tomb. The sacrifice of Polyxena is one of the principal themes of Euripides' tragedy *Hecuba*, in which the dignity and virtue of Polyxena are a striking contrast to the violence of the young Greeks and their leaders. Thus the aftermath of the war involved the sacrifice of a maiden before the Greek army just as it had been preceded by the sacrifice of Iphigenia. In a version especially popular in medieval legend, Polyxena had been loved by Achilles, and it was while he was meeting her that he was ambushed and killed by Paris.

Odysseus and Ajax Compete for the Armor of Achilles

Achilles' armor was claimed by both Odysseus and Ajax, son of Telamon, as the leading warriors surviving on the Greek side. Each made a speech before

an assembly of the Greeks, presided over by Athena. Trojan prisoners gave evidence that Odysseus had done them more harm than Ajax, and the arms were awarded to Odysseus. The disgrace of losing sent Ajax mad; he slaughtered a flock of sheep (which he believed were his enemies) and on becoming sane again killed himself for shame by falling on his sword. From his blood sprang a flower (perhaps a type of hyacinth) with the initials of his name (AI-AI) on its petals.²⁷

This legend is the subject of Sophocles' tragedy *Ajax*, in which the hostility of Athena toward Ajax contrasts with Odysseus' appreciation of the human predicament. Athena asks Odysseus if he knows of a hero who was greater than Ajax, and his reply is a final commentary on the heroic tragedy of the *Iliad* (Sophocles, *Ajax* 121–133):

ODYSSEUS: I do not know [of a greater hero]. I pity him in his misery, nevertheless, although he is my enemy. Because he is yoked to evil madness [*ate*], I look at this man's troubles no more than at my own. For I see that we who live are nothing more than ghosts and weightless shadows. (121–126)

ATHENA: Therefore when you see such things, say nothing yourself against the gods and swear no boastful oath if your hand is heavy [with success] or with deep and enduring wealth. For time lays low and brings back again all human things. The gods love those who are moderate [*sophrones*] and hate those who are evil. (127–133)

We can hardly find a better expression of the way in which the Greeks used mythology to express their deepest understanding of human life.

The Roman poet Ovid tells the story of Ajax and the armor of Achilles at length. Here is how he describes its end (*Metamorphoses* 13. 382–398):

The Greek leaders were impressed [i.e., by the speech of Odysseus], and the power of eloquence was made clear in the consequences. The eloquent man took away the armor of the brave warrior. Ajax, who alone so many times had resisted Hector, who had opposed iron missiles and fire and the will of Jupiter, could not resist one thing, anger. Shame conquered the unconquered hero. He seized the sword and thrust the lethal blade into his breast, never before wounded. The ground reddened with his blood and put forth a purple flower from the green grass, the flower which earlier had sprung from the wound of Hyacinthus. The same letters were written on the petals for hero and youth, for the one signifying his name, for the other the mourning cry.

10

The Deaths of Paris and Priam

After Achilles' death, Odysseus captured Helenus, who told the Greeks of a number of conditions that must be fulfilled before they could capture the city. Among these conditions was the summoning of two absent heroes, Neoptolemus (Pyrrhus) and Philoctetes. As we have mentioned, Philoctetes was brought from Lemnos, cured of his snakebite, and with his indispensable bow and arrows shot Paris. Neoptolemus (his name means "new recruit"), the son of Achilles, proved himself to be a brutal warrior; his butchering of Priam at the altar during the sack of Troy is one of the most moving scenes in the *Aeneid*. Vergil's description of Priam's remains echoes a familiar theme: the once mighty king now "lies, a great and mutilated body, head torn from the shoulders, a nameless corpse on the seashore" (2. 557–558).

The Wooden Horse

The Greeks finally took the city by deception. One of them, **Epeus**, built an enormous hollow wooden horse, in which the leading warriors were concealed. The *Iliad* does not mention the Trojan horse, which is repeatedly mentioned in the *Odyssey*. In Book 8 the bard, **Demodocus**, sings a second song at the request of Odysseus, whose identity has not yet been revealed (*Odyssey* 8. 487–495):

[Odysseus speaks:] “Demodocus, I honor you above all mortals. A Muse, daughter of Zeus, was your teacher, or Apollo, for well do you sing in proper order of the sorrows of the Greeks—their deeds and sufferings and labors—as if you yourself had been there or had heard them from another. Come now, and change your song: sing of the wooden horse, which Epeus made with the help of Athena. Odysseus brought it as a deception into the acropolis [of Troy], when he had filled it with men who sacked Troy.”



The Building of the Trojan Horse, by Giovanni Domenico Tiepolo (1727–1804); oil on canvas, 1773, 76 × 141 in. This huge painting is the only survivor of three final versions of a series on The Fall of Troy, for which all three preparatory oil sketches exist. The massive horse dominates the composition, as workmen with their tools and ladders swarm over it. To the left two figures stand on a rock outside the walls of Troy, probably Epeus (gesturing) and, behind him, Odysseus disguised with a turban and ill-fitting cloak. In the background are the walls of Troy, in front of which a warrior, a woman with a baby, and a servant (possibly, if improbably, Hector and his family) observe the building, while other Trojans look down from the tower on the left. (Wadsworth Atheneum Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look

Demodocus then tells the story of the horse, in which Odysseus has the most prominent role (*Odyssey* 8. 502–515):

They [i.e., the Greek heroes] sat around glorious Odysseus in the center of Troy, concealed in the horse, for the Trojans themselves had dragged it up to the acropolis. Thus it stood there, and the Trojans sat and debated around it. They favored three plans: either to drive a sharp bronze [spear] through its hollow belly, or to drag it to the edge of the precipice and throw it down the rocks, or to let it be a great dedication to placate the gods. This was the course which they would choose, for it was fated that they would be destroyed once the city held the great wooden horse, where sat all the noblest of the Argives, bringing slaughter and fate to the Trojans. He sang, too, how the sons of Achaeans sacked the city when they poured out of the horse, leaving their hollow place of ambush. 10

“This was the bard’s song,” says Homer, and Odysseus wept when he heard it, even as a woman weeps whose husband has been killed in battle—the very suffering that Odysseus himself had inflicted on the Trojans. The song of Demodocus is the basis for Vergil’s detailed account of the sack of Troy in the second book of the *Aeneid*. Odysseus himself tells the story of the horse to the ghost of Achilles in the Underworld, narrating how only Achilles’ son, Neoptolemus, had been fearless and eager to fight as he sat waiting in the horse, whereas the other Greek heroes had wept and their knees were weak with fear. Odysseus is shown in both of these accounts to be the leader of the Greeks in the horse.

The horse was left outside the city walls, while the other Greeks sailed off to the island of Tenedos, leaving behind one man, **Sinon**. The Trojans, thinking that their troubles were over, came out of the city and captured Sinon, who pretended to be the bitter enemy of Odysseus and the other Greeks. He told the Trojans that the horse was an offering to Athena, purposely made too big to pass through the city walls; if it were brought inside, the city would never be captured. Not all the Trojans believed him; Cassandra, the prophetic daughter of Priam, foretold the truth, and **Laocoön**, son of Antenor and priest of Apollo, hurled his spear into the horse’s flank and said that it should be destroyed. Yet the Trojans ignored Cassandra and failed to hear the clash of armor as Laocoön’s spear struck the horse. Their judgment appeared to be vindicated when two huge serpents swam over the sea from Tenedos as Laocoön was sacrificing to Apollo and throttled him and his two sons.

The Sack of Troy

The Trojans pulled down part of the city walls and dragged the horse in. Helen walked round it calling to the Greek leaders, imitating the voice of each one’s wife, but they were restrained from answering by Odysseus.²⁸ So the horse achieved its purpose; that night, as the Trojans slept after celebrating the end of the war, Sinon opened the horse and released the Greeks. The other Greeks sailed back from Tenedos and entered the city; the Trojans were put to the sword and the city was burned.

Antenor was spared, and of the other Trojan leaders only Aeneas escaped, along with his son, Ascanius, and his father, Anchises. Priam and the others

were killed; Hector's infant son, Astyanax, was thrown from the walls, and his widow, Andromache, along with Hecuba and the other Trojan women, were made slaves of the Greek leaders. Neoptolemus' share of the spoil included Andromache, but eventually she married Helenus and founded the dynasty of the Molossian kings. In Book 3 of the *Aeneid*, she and Helenus figure prominently. She is the only one of the Trojan women to regain some sort of independent status after the fall of Troy.

During the sack of the city, Cassandra took refuge in the temple of Athena. She was dragged from this asylum by Ajax the Locrian, son of Oileus, and for this he was killed by the gods on his way home.²⁹ Cassandra became the slave and concubine of Agamemnon, who took her back to Mycenae, where she was murdered with him by Clytemnestra. In Aeschylus' play *Agamemnon*, she foresees her own death in a moving scene (see p. 442); yet her audience, the Chorus in the play, does not believe her. The curse of Apollo remained with her to the end.

As Hecuba sailed back to Greece with Odysseus (to whom she had been given as part of the spoils), she landed in Thrace and there recognized the corpse of her son Polydorus when it was washed up on the seashore. He had been murdered by the local king Polymestor (to whom he had been sent for safety during the war) because of the treasure that had been sent with him. Taking advantage of Polymestor's avarice, Hecuba enticed him and his children into her tent, pretending that she knew the whereabouts in Troy of some hidden treasure, while she appeared to know nothing of the murder of Polydorus. Once they were in the tent, Hecuba's women murdered the children before Polymestor's eyes, then blinded him with their brooches. After this, Hecuba was turned into a bitch; when she died, the place of her burial (in Thrace) was called Cynossema, which means the "dog's tomb."



The Sack of Troy. Attic red-figure hydria by the Kleophrades painter, ca. 480 B.C.; height of vase 16 ½ in., height of painting 6 ½ in. In the upper picture, Priam sits on the altar with the dead and mutilated Astyanax across his knees, as Neoptolemus rushes forward to kill him. Behind Neoptolemus a Trojan woman attacks with a clublike implement. In the lower image, Ascanius, on the left (helmeted), leads the way for Aeneas, who carries Anchises on his back (Anchises looks back toward the central scene). In the center, Ajax Oileus brutally drags Cassandra from the statue of Athena, whose threatening stance foreshadows his fate. Between the statue and a palm tree, Trojan women grieve for their coming fate. (Scala/Art Resource, NY)

The Trojan Women of Euripides

In Euripides' tragedy the *Trojan Women*, the results of the fall are seen through the eyes of Hecuba, Cassandra, and Andromache. The death of Astyanax is a

central part of the tragedy, in which he is torn from his mother's embrace to be hurled from the walls. Later, his body is brought back on stage and placed by Hecuba on the shield of Hector, a symbol of the defenselessness of Troy once her champion had been killed. The chorus of Trojan captives recalls the entry of the wooden horse (*Trojan Women* 515–541):

Now I shall sing of Troy, how I was destroyed by the four-wheeled contrivance of the Greeks and made their prisoner, when they left the horse at the gates, echoing to the skies with the clash of armor and caparisoned with gold. And the Trojan people shouted as it stood on the rock of Troy: "Come, the labor of war is over! Bring in this wooden horse as a holy offering to the daughter of Zeus, guardian of Troy!" Who of the young women did not go, who of the old men stayed at home? Charmed by music, they took hold of the treacherous means of their destruction. All the Phrygian people gathered at the gates, and with ropes of flax they dragged it, like the dark hull of a ship, to the stone temple's floor, bringing death to their city—the temple of the goddess Pallas. 10



The Flight of Aeneas from Troy, by Federico Barocci (1535–1612); oil on canvas, 1598, 17 ½ × 101 in. Barocci faithfully represents Vergil's narrative. The central group of Aeneas, Ascanius, and Anchises (who is clutching the household gods of Troy) is separated from Creusa, who falls behind. In the foreground are Aeneas' shield and spear, now useless, while in the background is a round temple, the *Tempietto* of the Roman church of San Pietro in Montorio, in the portico and gallery of which men are fighting. Beside the temple is the column of Marcus Aurelius, and in the flames behind are the figures of the gods hostile to Troy. Barocci's signature is on the base of the newel-post on the left. (Alinari/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look

The Sack of Troy in the *Aeneid*

The principal source for the fall of Troy is the second book of the *Aeneid*. Here is how Vergil describes the horror of the end of a city deserted by its divine protectors in Aeneas' vision at the climactic moment of the sack, as his mother, Venus, allows him a moment of divine insight (*Aeneid* 2. 602–606, 608–625):³⁰

[Aeneas recalls the words of Venus:] “It is the pitiless gods, the gods who are destroying the wealth of Troy and laying the city low from top to bottom. Look—for I will remove the cloud that now dulls your mortal sight. . . . Here, where you see the shattered towers and huge stones torn up, where dust and smoke are billowing, Neptune is convulsing the walls, shaking the foundations with his trident as he uproots the city. Here Juno, most cruel, leads the others in seizing the Scaean gates: raging and clad in iron armor she calls the Greeks from the ships. Look over here—even now Tritonian Pallas has taken up her place upon the height of Troy's citadel: see how she is lit with the lurid storm-cloud and the ferocious Gorgon! The Father of the gods himself renews the courage and violence of the Greeks, himself he urges them on to fight. . . .”

I saw the fatal vision and the mighty power of the gods hostile to Troy. Then, indeed, I saw all Ilium collapse into the flames and Troy, built by Neptune, overturned from its foundations.

Yet Aeneas escaped, taking with him his father, Anchises (who carried the images of the city's gods in his hands), and his son, Ascanius (also called Iulus). His wife, **Creusa**, started with him and was lost to Aeneas' sight. Only her ghost appeared to him, foretelling his destiny and encouraging him to travel to a new world. The scene of Aeneas leaving Troy is heavy with symbolism, and it is with hope for the future that Aeneas, burdened with the past, leaves the doomed city (*Aeneid* 2. 707–711, 721–724):

“Then come, dear father, sit on my shoulders; I will carry you, the load will not weigh me down. Whatever chance may fall, we will share a common danger and a common salvation. Let little Iulus walk beside me and let my wife follow. . . .” With these words I spread my cloak and the skin of a tawny lion across my shoulders and neck and lifted the burden. Little Iulus took my right hand and, hardly able to keep up, walked beside his father.



Flight from Troy (1618–1619). Detail of a marble statue by Gian-Lorenzo Bernini (1598–1680); height in 86 ½ in. This is Bernini's first major work, executed when he was 20 years old. Unlike Barocci, he focuses exclusively on the central figures of the flight—Aeneas, solemn, young, and strong; Anchises, clutching his son and, in his wide-eyed gaze, recognizing the implications of the destruction of Troy; finally, the city's household gods, whose preservation will lead eventually to the foundation of a new Troy in another land. Not seen in this detail is Ascanius (Iulus), who stumbles along beside the left leg of Aeneas. (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)

Appendix: Meleager and the Calydonian Boar Hunt

In the *Iliad*, as we have seen, Agamemnon sends Phoenix as one of the three envoys to Achilles in an attempt to assuage him. Phoenix, tutor, friend, and surrogate father at Troy, addresses Achilles at length, urging him to conquer his stubborn pride and give up his wrath. At the core of his speech (9. 524–599), he offers as a warning the story of Meleager.

After the famous Calydonian boar hunt, in a quarrel over the slain animal, Meleager killed the brother (or brothers) of his mother **Althaea**. In her terrible grief, she prayed for her son's death. In the war between the Aetolians, who were defending their city of Calydon, and the Curetes, who were laying siege to the city, as long as Meleager fought with the Aetolians, things went well for them. Yet, when Meleager was overwhelmed by passion because of blind rage against his mother Althaea, he withdrew from battle.

The Curetes reached the gates of Calydon, and the Aetolians in desperation appealed to Meleager to return to battle, offering him splendid gifts. But he refused. As the Curetes were pillaging the city, Meleager's wife **Cleopatra** begged him in tears to come to their rescue. He was moved by her appeals. Compelled by his own conscience, he saved the city and the people but got none of the rich rewards that they had offered him for returning.

And so, Phoenix admonished Achilles not to behave like Meleager, but to accept the generous gifts promised by Agamemnon now and return to battle.

The legend of Meleager and the Calydonian boar hunt is an important one but difficult to present as a single, coherent narrative because of conflicting versions, as the summary that follows will make clear. The text of Homer itself offers its own confusion.

The François Vase is an appropriate final illustration for this chapter. It depicts not only the Calydonian boar hunt, with Meleager and Peleus, the father of Achilles, but also scenes from the Trojan War.

Among the descendants of Aeolus was Oeneus, king of Calydon and father of Heracles' wife Deïanira; his son was Meleager. Shortly after the birth of Meleager, the Fates (Moirai) appeared before his mother, Althaea, and told her that Meleager would die when a log, which was burning on the hearth, had burned out. Althaea snatched up the log, extinguished it, and kept it in a chest. Years later, when Meleager was a young man, Oeneus offended Artemis by failing to sacrifice her share of the first fruits, and the goddess sent a huge boar to ravage Calydon.

Meleager gathered many of the noblest Greek heroes to hunt the boar, and with them came **Atalanta**, daughter of the Boeotian king Schoeneus.³¹ In the hunt, after several heroes had been killed, Atalanta was the first to wound the boar. Meleager gave it the coup de grâce and therefore received the boar's skin, which he presented to Atalanta. His uncles, the brothers of Althaea, were insulted at being given less honor than Atalanta, and in the ensuing quarrel Meleager killed them. In grief and anger at their deaths, Althaea took the unburned log from its chest and cast it on the fire. As it burned to ashes, Meleager's life ebbed away. Both Althaea and Meleager's wife Cleopatra hanged themselves, while the women who mourned for him at his funeral became guinea fowl, which the Greeks called *meleagrides*.

This is Ovid's version of the Calydonian boar hunt. Homer, however (*Iliad* 9. 553–572), says that Artemis sent the boar to ravage the land during a



The François Vase. Attic black-figure krater by the potter Ergotimos and the painter Kleitias, ca. 575 B.C.; height 30 in. There are four bands of mythological scenes and a fifth band with plants and animals, a battle of pygmies and cranes on the foot, and more figures, including Ajax carrying the corpse of Achilles, on the handles. The detail (below the image of the whole vase) shows the top bands on one side: Meleager and Peleus thrust at the Calydonian boar with their spears, with Atalanta and Milonion behind them. A dead hound and hunter lie on the ground, and other hunters (all named) attack or prepare to attack the beast. The band below shows the chariot race from the funeral games for Patroclus: Diomedes leads Damasippus, and the prize, a tripod, is shown below to the left. The third band on the full vase shows the wedding procession of Peleus and Thetis, who are on the chariot to the left. The band below shows Achilles pursuing Troilus: on the left is the fountain-house where Polyxena (sister of Troilus) had been drawing water. To its right a Trojan woman gesticulates in alarm, and next to her (in order) are Thetis, Hermes, and Athena, the latter urging on Achilles (the top half of whose body is missing). Troilus rides a horse beside a second riderless horse, and beneath lies Polyxena's amphora, which she has dropped in her flight. She runs in front of Troilus (her top half is missing) toward the walls of Troy, from which two armed warriors, Hector and Polites, are emerging. In front of Troy sits Priam, who is receiving a report from Antenor about the danger to Troilus. (Top: Nimatallah/Art Resource, NY; Bottom: Scala/Art Resource, NY)

war between the Calydonians and the Curetes. Meleager killed it and led the Calydonians in the battle against the Curetes over the boar's body. But Althaea cursed her son Meleager "because of the murder of her brother" and called on Hades to kill him. Meleager withdrew in anger. Then he relented, went back into battle, and saved Calydon. Homer says that the Calydonians did not reward him as they had promised, and he implies that Meleager died as a result of Althaea's curse.

In the Underworld, Meleager's ghost talked with Heracles, and in Bacchylides' fifth *Epinician Ode* (93–154) he tells Heracles his story, in which the

Homeric details of the boar and the battle with the Curetes are combined with the burning log:

There [i.e., in the battle with the Curetes] I killed with many others Iphiclus and Aphares, my mother's swift brothers; for bold Ares does not distinguish a friend in war, but blind are the weapons hurled from one's hands. My mother, ill-fated and unfearing woman, planned my death. She burned the log that brought me a speedy death, taking it from the cunningly made chest. It had the *Moirai* [i.e., allotted portion] fated to be the limit of my life. And my sweet life ebbed, and I knew that I was losing my strength—alas!—and unhappily I wept as I breathed my last, leaving lovely youth.

In this version, although Meleager accidentally kills his uncles in battle, their sister still avenges their death, her ties to her father's family being even stronger than those to her son. As Bacchylides also tells us, Heracles responded to Meleager's story with a promise to marry Deianira, Meleager's sister, when he returned to the world of the living (see p. 566).

Nowhere in Homer or Bacchylides is there any mention of Atalanta, nor is there any complete account of her part in the legend earlier than Ovid. She appears in the François Vase, which was made in about 575 B.C., a century before Bacchylides' poem. About 165 years later, in 411–410 B.C., Euripides says in his play *Phoenissae* (1104–1109) that Atalanta's son, Parthenopaeus, one of the seven heroes who attacked Thebes, had the device on his shield of "Atalanta subduing the Aetolian boar with her arrows shot from afar," whereas in the François Vase she brandishes a hunting spear and marches in the second rank, behind Meleager and Peleus. Finally, her companion on the vase is named Milanion, who wins the Arcadian Atalanta as his bride in yet another tale.

From all this, we can conclude that several legends have been conflated around Meleager and Atalanta, whose myths were originally separate. Ovid created a unified narrative from these different elements.

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Sources in the Chapter

Bacchylides	<i>Epinician Ode</i> 5.93–154
Euripides	<i>Trojan Women</i> 515–541
Homer	<i>Iliad</i> (selections)
	<i>Odyssey</i> 8.487–495, 502–515; 24.63–70

Homeric Hymn 17	<i>To the Dioscuri</i>
Homeric Hymn 33	<i>To the Dioscuri</i> (see p. 468)
Lucian	<i>Dialogues of the Gods: The Judgment of the Goddesses</i> 7–16
Lucretius	<i>De rerum natura</i> 1.84–101 (sacrifice of Iphigenia)
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 13.382–398
Sophocles	<i>Ajax</i> 121–133
Statius	1.852–884
Vergil	<i>Aeneid</i> 2.602–606, 608–625, 707–711, 721–724

Additional Sources

Euripides	<i>Andromache</i> <i>Hecuba</i> <i>Helen</i> <i>Rhesus</i>
Ovid	<i>Heroides</i>
Plato	<i>Lesser Hippias</i> (Hippias Minor) 363a–365c (the <i>Iliad</i> and <i>Odyssey</i> compared), 369a–372e (Achilles and Odysseus compared)
Seneca	<i>Trojan Women</i>
Sophocles	<i>Philoctetes</i>

Notes

1. Pindar, *Nemean Ode* 10. In Theocritus, *Idyll* 22, the quarrel begins when the Dioscuri carry off the daughters of Leucippus from their intended husbands, Idas and Lynceus. The “rape of the Leucippides” was a common subject in ancient art. Another version has one of the divine twins in heaven and the other in Hades on alternate days.
2. Euripides brings them on dramatically at the end of his *Electra*, not only as the protectors of sailors but also as champions of a better morality than that represented by Apollo (see p. 464).
3. Their appearance as horsemen on white steeds at the battle of Lake Regillus in 496 led to a great Roman victory.
4. Aphrodite is said (also by Stesichorus) to have made Helen unfaithful as punishment for Helen’s father, Tyndareus, who had once omitted to sacrifice to the goddess. For Helen in Egypt, see Herodotus 2. 112–120 and Euripides, *Helen*.
5. Hecuba’s stepson, Aesacus.
6. For the historical facts about Troy and the Trojan War, see pp. 46–51.
7. Laomedon was a nephew of Ganymede, whom Zeus had snatched up to Olympus to become the cupbearer of the gods (pp. 123–124). In compensation, Zeus gave Tros (father of Ganymede) the divine horses that Laomedon inherited and failed to give to Heracles.
8. The story of Troilus’ love for Cressida (daughter, in this version, of Calchas) is an invention of the Middle Ages; Boccaccio and Chaucer took the story from the *Roman de Troie* of Benoît de Ste. Maure. Shakespeare’s play is a further variation.
9. Although the contingents supplied by Odysseus, king of Ithaca, and Ajax, prince of Salamis, were among the smallest (only twelve ships each), their personal prowess gave them preeminence.
10. The comparative importance of the Greek leaders may be gauged from the size of their contingents in the *Catalogue* in Book 2 of the *Iliad*: Agamemnon, one hundred ships; Nestor, ninety; Diomedes and Idomeneus, eighty each; Menelaüs, sixty;